Geniuses

By Abbey Fenbert

CHARACTERS:
POLLY: *a ten-year-old with a penchant for scientific observation.*
WILFRED: *her long-suffering twin brother with a penchant for setting things on fire.*

WILFRED: I'm really sorry about what happened. *(POLLY does not answer. She reaches for a notebook and pen and begins to write.)*

POLLY: 'Sunday, eighty-forty-five p.m. Wilfred issues an apology. Uninspired. Insincere.'

WILFRED: Hey, stop that! It was not insincere!

POLLY: Do you even know what 'insincere' means?

WILFRED: Do so. Lacking earnesty. Honestness. I mean ... It was one of our Reading Words last week.

POLLY: I see.

WILFRED: Look, I'm sorry.

POLLY: *(writing)* 'Eight forty-seven. Wilfred attempts repeat apology. Truncated.'

WILFRED: Stop logging me.

POLLY: 'Wilfred projects displaced hostility upon the log.'

WILFRED: I give up. *(Silence between the twins. Then ...)*

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INTRODUCTION

Intro starts with actors still in character:

ACTRESS: Twins . . . God's way of saying (Pointing to Actor) "One of you is a rough draft!"

ACTOR: Be honest though. Isn't life so much better when you have a twin to share the ride?

ACTRESS: Hey, I may be a twin, but I am one of a kind! (Drop character)

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POLLY: A substantial apology, Wilfred, must fulfill a number of basic requirements. For one thing, you should enumerate your offenses, rather than vaguely alluding to 'what happened.' The word 'sorry' ought to be voiced in an emphatic tone. And at the very least you should be on your feet. *(Pause. WILFRED sighs, then shu.ffies to his feet and stands before POLLY)*

WILFRED: Polly. I am very SORRY that I did not prepare a project for the science competition, because I was extremely busy the whole week, as George and I were trying to catch a possum, which turned out to be a cat-and I am deeply APOLOGETIC that in order to find an entry to the science competition at the last minute I dug up Old Lady Spencer's rare chrysanthemum, then placed it in the tank where you were keeping your project-and I am extremely full of REMORSE that the chrysanthemum was loaded with pesticides and poisons that killed all the insects in the tank, thus forcing the salamanders to resort to cannibalism. I'm sorry. *(Very long pause as POLLY regards WILFRED.)*

POLLY: *(clapping)* That was very good! *(POLLY retrieves a gold star sticker and affixes it to WILFRED'S forehead.)*

WILFRED: Hey ... !

POLLY: *(writing in log)* 'Sunday, Eight-fifty-four. Following explicit and careful instruction, Wilfred demonstrates mastery of fundamental apologetic techniques.' Just one thing, *though-newts.*

WILFRED: What?

POLLY: Newts, Wilfred. My science experiment had to do with the habits of newts, not salamanders. They are quite similar, but they are ultimately not the same.

WILFRED: Oh. Sorry.

POLLY: All right, now, no need to go overboard on the sorries. One might start to suspect you're getting greedy for gold stars! *(WILFRED seethes. POLLY scribbles happily in log.)*

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WILFRED: Well. There may be one or two other things I haven't gotten round to apologizing over.

POLLY: *(still writing, distracted)* To be expected.

WILFRED: For example, I'm sorry I told Aunt Linda you were the one who shaved her dog's ears.

POLLY: Fascinating.

WILFRED: I'm also ... distraught ... that I used your red wagon to haul manure and didn't clean it up afterwards.

POLLY: 'Distraught'?

WILFRED: Reading word.

POLLY: Ah.

WILFRED: I'm sorry I used your toothbrush to scrub the toilet.

POLLY: Wilfred!

WILFRED: Do you think you can ever forgive me for telling Brian Fletchley that you've written twelve sonnets on the subject of his eyebrows?

POLLY: How dare you!

WILFRED: I'm also so, so, sorry that I poured maple syrup all over your favorite microscope.

POLLY: You haven't done that.

WILFRED: I plan to. Sorry!

POLLY: *(writing)* '9 o'clock p.m. Wilfred devolving rapidly. Abhorrent, filthy, repugnant child.'

WILFRED: I'll show you who's an Ab Hornet! *(WILFRED snatches log.from POLLY, shoves her aside. Punctuates rant by tearing pages from log.)*

WILFRED: Now, yesterday, a million years from now and forever, Polly is an annoying, stuck-up, bullying brainiac who deserves to have all her toothbrushes used as toilet scrubs!

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POLLY: No! *(POLLY lunges at WILFRED to save her log, but WILFRED kicks her away and leaps triumphant on the bed, where he completes the destruction of the log.)*

WILFRED: I ... always ... *hated* ... those gold stars!

POLLY: You rotten fool! You've ruined everything. That was my science project! *(POLLY grabs one of the torn sheets and begins to sob.)*

WILFRED: What are you talking about? That's just your stupid log.

POLLY: Idiot. The log was my entry into the competition! *You* were the subject.

WILFRED: No ... I thought it was that fat salamander that ate all the others ...

POLLY: Well it wasn't, it was you! I spent hours observing and monitoring and recording ... And now it's all destroyed ... My academic reputation in shambles ... And he wasn't a salamander, he was a newt! *(Renewed sobs.)*

WILFRED: What do you mean, I'm a science experiment?

POLLY: Isn't it obvious? The mediocre, thoroughly undistinguished twin sibling of a genius.

WILFRED: Thanks a lot.

POLLY: How can it be we shared a womb, but not a mind? How can we be so similar in so many ways, and yet so fundamentally different? How does the unimpressive sibling cope with the daily challenge of interacting with a superior mind?

WILFRED: It copes fine!

POLLY: I was so careful, so detailed ... My report was going to break new ground in the scholarship of the merely normal! *(POLLY collapses in sobs. WILFRED sulks.)*

WILFRED: Polly ... Polly, stop. *(POLLY continues to sob.)* Polly ...

POLLY: Y-yes?

WILFRED: Does this mean I can use the fat salamander?

POLLY: *(rising)* He ... was ... a ... *NEWT!* *(POLLY and WILFRED face off, close in on each*

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other menacingly with each shout.)

WILFRED: Salamander!

POLLY: Newt!

WILFRED: Salamander!

POLLY: Newt!

(WILFRED shouts "Salamander, Salamander, Salamander!" as POLLY begins an equally annoying rant of "Newt Newt Newt!" It builds to an unbearable peak until a loud thumping- as if someone is banging on a wall or the ceiling below-is heard. The twins freeze. A pause.)

WILFRED/ POLLY: Sorry mother! *(The following is carried out in strained whispers.)*

OLLY: Now look what you've done!

WILFRED: Me! This is your fault, for being such an Ab Hornet!

POLLY: Classic Wilfredian blunder-just the kind of thing that always makes our parents take irrational pity on you.

WILFRED: Believe me, they'll pity you plenty after I'm through.

POLLY: Are you threatening violence? Well-they'll hear!

WILFRED: Not if I rip all your hairs out. Very. Quietly.

POLLY: Don't forget, brother dear, that I happen to know shortcuts to all your essential arteries. *(seizes up pen)* You won't have time to scream!

WILFRED: *(raising hands to strangling position)* Neither will you if I'm choking you!

POLLY: I always knew it would come to this! *(They are poised to attack. Another thump.)*

WILFRED/ POLLY: WE'RE BEING QUIET! *(Thump.)*

WILFRED: *(an epiphany)* Polly!

POLLY: What?

WILFRED: I just had a thought.

POLLY: For the first time, I presume?

WILFRED: Do you think our parents ... could be doing an experiment on us? *(POLLY scoffs, but is begrudgingly intrigued Lowers pen.)*

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POLLY: Elaborate.

WILFRED: I mean ... Newts, salamanders, siblings ... Do you think they've shut us in this room together and are just waiting to see how long it takes us to resort to cannibalism?

POLLY: That's complete and utter ...

WILFRED: Fine, laugh ...

POLLY: Genius!

WILFRED: Wait.

POLLY: Wilfred! That's brilliant! Why else would they force two such fundamentally alien individuals into close, hostile contact with few outlets for respite if not to monitor our responses to the extremities of these conditions?

WILFRED: ... Exactly!

POLLY: The shared room, the inequitable distribution of household labor -- they hope to profit scholastically from our suffering. It all makes sense!

WILFRED: We're lab rats.

POLLY: They must have shelves of logs.

WILFRED: And beakers, and chemicals!

POLLY: It's the only plausible hypothesis.

WILFRED: They could be spying on us right now ...

POLLY: Oh, Wilfred, you genius, you genius! Now we can take a leaf from your log, and min their whole experiment.

WILFRED: With fire!

POLLY: No, Wilfred, not with fire-with subterfuge. We mustn't give dear mother and father what they want.

WILFRED: Never.

POLLY: We won't resort to cannibalism!

WILFRED: We'll act like we like each other!

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POLLY: Be helpful, encouraging ...

WILFRED: Play fair ...

POLLY: *(taking WILFRED'S hand)* Hold hands! Oh foolish parents, you'll rue the day you tried to trick us!

WILFRED: Yeah! You will so rue! ... But let's not hold hands.

POLLY: Agreed. Wilfred. We'll have to commit. Until we find those logs, we've got to be the most loving and congenial pair of twins that ever was.

WILFRED: Anything it takes to get back at them. And then we'll find those papers ...

POLLY: Yes!

WILFRED: And set them on fire!

POLLY: No!

WILFRED: Aw. I'm really good at fire.

POLLY: We have to make a copy first. Then we can set them on fire.

WILFRED: A copy ... for blackmail!

POLLY: Precisely!

WILFRED: Genius.

POLLY: But we must make sure to hide the copies in a place where they'll never, ever be found.

WILFRED: In a salamander tank?

POLLY: Newt=-oh, it doesn't matter. They're a little different, but ...

WILFRED: Ultimately the same. *(WILFRED and POLLY embrace. The End.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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